

Becoming a go-to person on your team



Course on Taro by Jordan Cutler

About me

- Senior Software Engineer at Pinterest 📌
- Worked across the stack but primarily frontend now
- Author: High Growth Engineer (70k+ subs)

Fun facts:

- 🎮 Used to play video games professionally
- 🐱 Lover of my 3 cats
- 🐶 My guilty pleasure is Netflix dating shows



Who is this course for?

- You want to master visibility by providing value
- You want to figure out what you enjoy and how to get rewarded for your work
- You want to grow your ownership, but you're not sure how

Course modules

- **Module 1: Why it's important to be a go-to person**
- **Module 2: What it means to be a go-to person**
- **Module 3: How to become a go-to person**



Quick reflection

Module 1



Why does this matter?



Irina Stanescu (She/Her) • [in](#) • 1st

Engineering Leader • My next cohort of "Impact through Influence" start...

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7mo • Edited •

I helped my first report at Google get promoted from Eng 1 to Eng 2 within 9 months, by advising her to find something that she can become the "the go-to person" for. She took my guidance really seriously and in no time became the team expert in a subsystem owned by another team, which helped her land the promotion. But why did I advise her that?

For an Eng 1, the scope she claimed was bigger than what was expected of her, as it involved complicated video transcoding pipelines. Nevertheless, she took my guidance and ran with it, understanding the ins and outs of that subsystem.

What she cleverly figured out was that by becoming the local expert on that transcoding system, she was saving our team cross-team communication time. Shortly, people more senior would come to her with questions and within months she was quite well known in the organization.

If you want to accelerate your growth and differentiate yourself among your peers, become a "go-to person" or an expert for something. It's almost like an unfair competitive advantage. There is always something people don't know enough of. Is it Docker, is it Kubernetes, is it how the database works, is it a specific JavaScript framework, or a niche transcoding pipeline? Find that thing and become the person everybody thinks of when they need advice or guidance.

This will grow your visibility, solidify your personal brand, and position yourself as an expert that people trust.

1,762

69 comments • 67 reposts



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Ethan Evans  • 1st

Retired Amazon VP, LinkedIn Top Voice, now Teaching Leaders to bec...

Visit my website

7mo • 



A VP with 80 Sr. Managers and senior ICs just told me that he watches to see who he thinks will be a VP in ten years so that he can invest in them. There is so much you can learn (and action on) from this statement!

First, he is actively looking and making choices. Just because your executive is not telling you who is on their list doesn't mean they lack one.

Second, in choosing who has potential, he is also choosing who does not. There is no malice in this, but there is an important and deadly reality. Those who impress with their potential will get support and opportunities that others will not, simply due to limited time and resources.

This VP is choosing who he thinks has the leadership skills, strategic insight, and drive to succeed at his own level in the future. Who has the potential to grow that far.

The important question (at any level) is what can YOU do to get on the mental short list of people worth extra investment and opportunity?



833

88 comments • 14 reposts



Addy Osmani • 1st

Engineering Leader, Google Chrome. Best-selling Author. Speaker. I w...

1mo •



"Becoming a go-to person gets you promoted. Here's how to do it as a software engineer"

As software engineers, we often focus on honing our technical skills, but there's another crucial aspect to career growth that's often overlooked: becoming a high-value "go-to" person or expert in your organization. In a recent article by [Jordan Cutler](#), he explains why this is essential for reaching senior levels and provides practical advice on how to achieve it.

<https://lnkd.in/geZczEuf>.

Becoming an expert doesn't mean having the final say on all decisions in a particular area. Instead, it's about being someone whose advice is sought after and who is seen as a leader within that domain. This could be in a technical area requiring depth, or in a product domain like the onboarding flow or payment portal. Cutler emphasizes that this expertise is often a key factor in promotion criteria at top tech companies.



You and 316 others

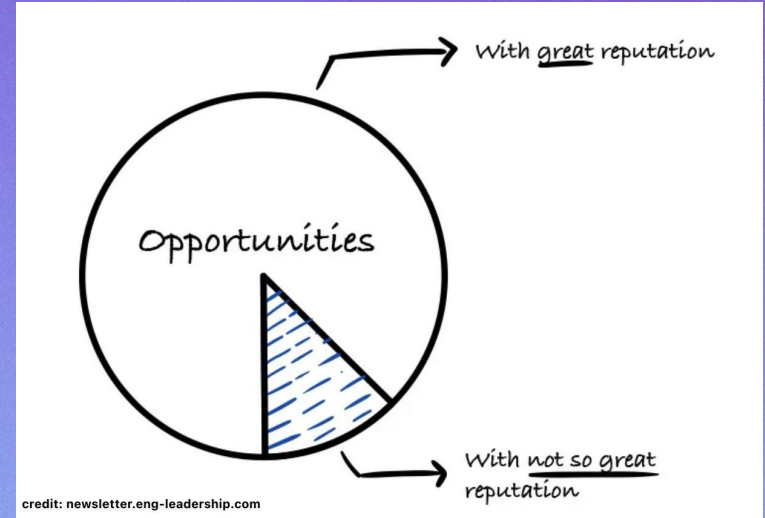
26 comments • 22 reposts

My story... 



Why it matters

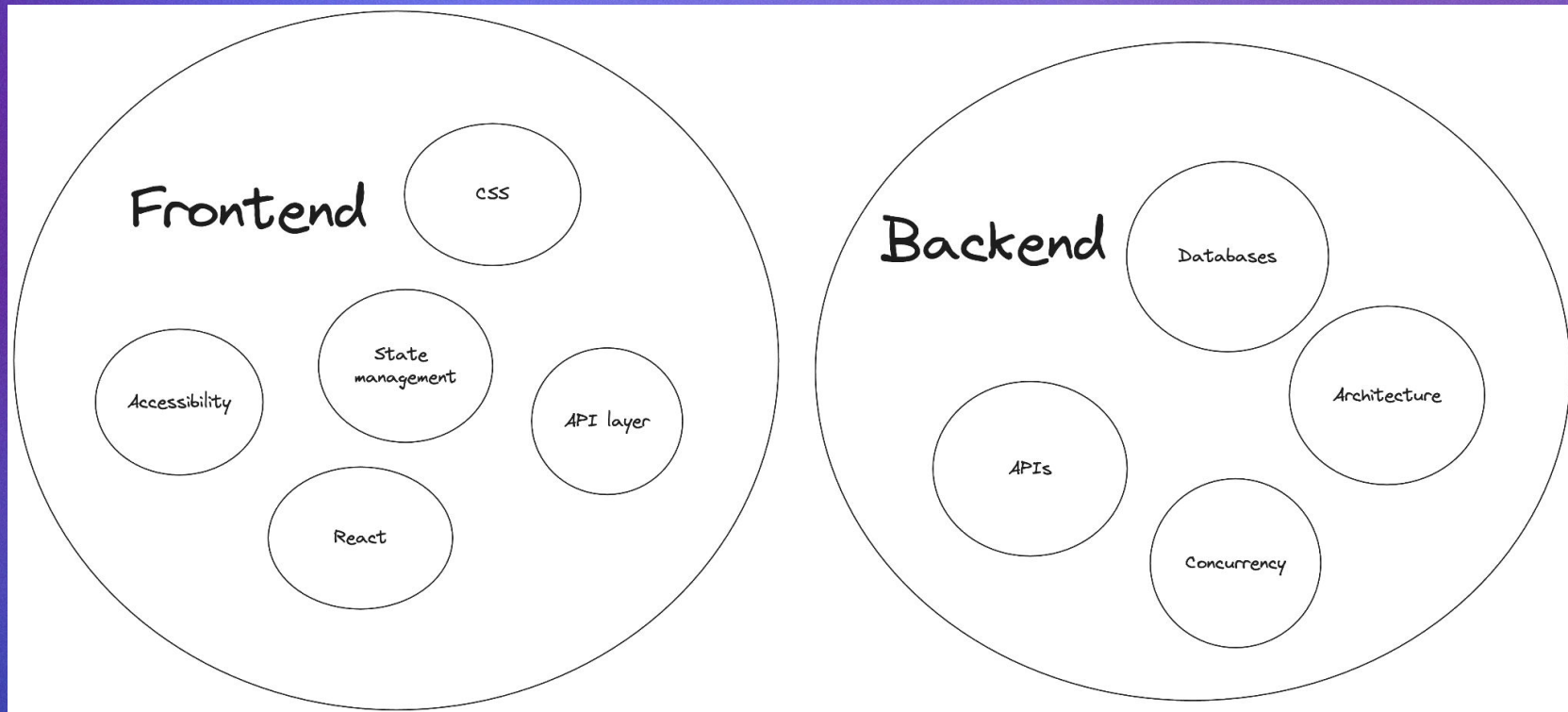
- You're seen as a leader.
You are the “something” expert.
That is senior.
- Implicit mentorship - Growing the team
- More opportunities & projects to build promotion case



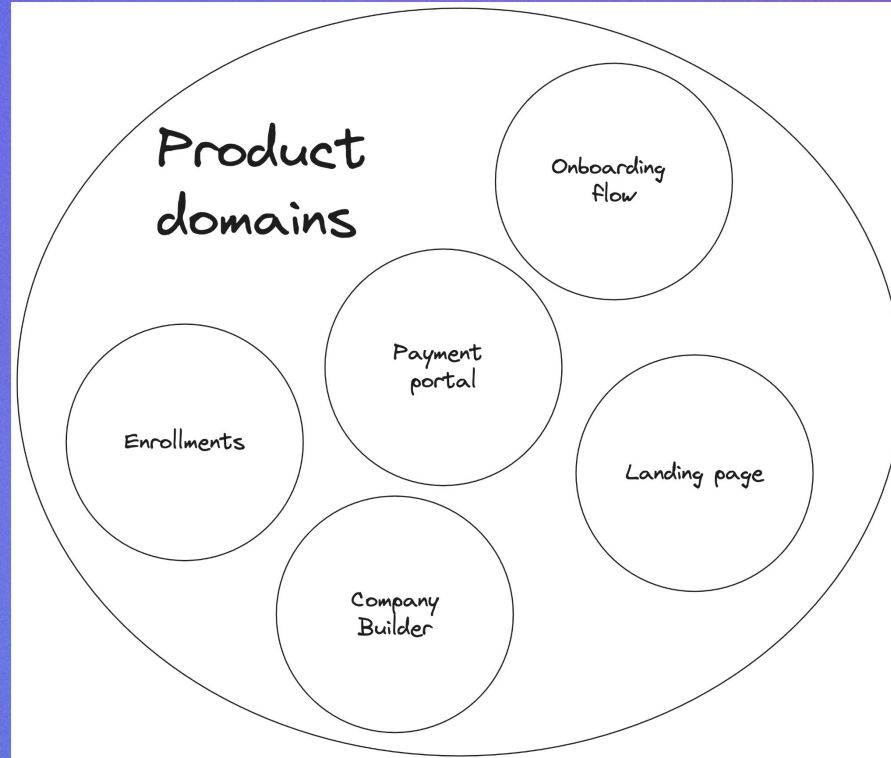
Module 2

What it means to be a go-to person

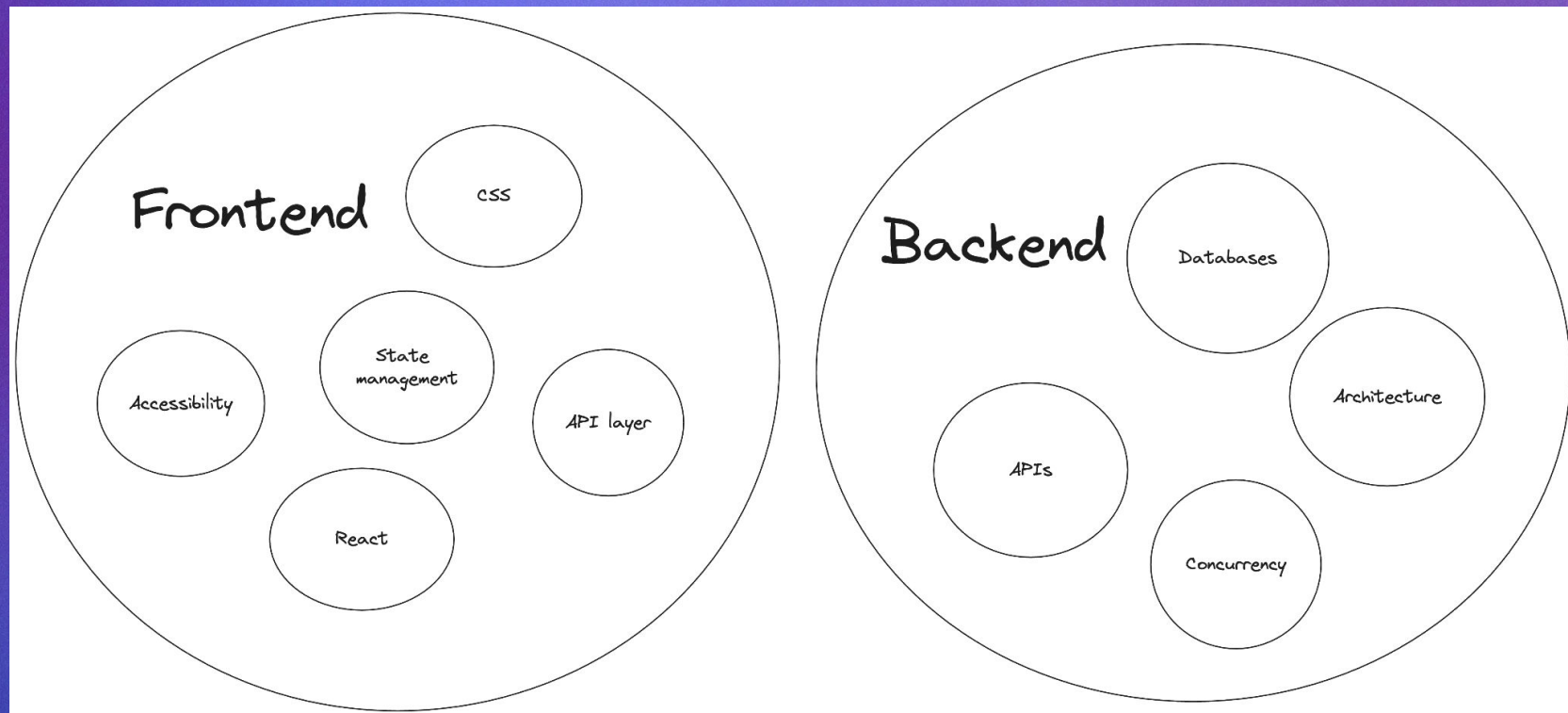
Technical expertise



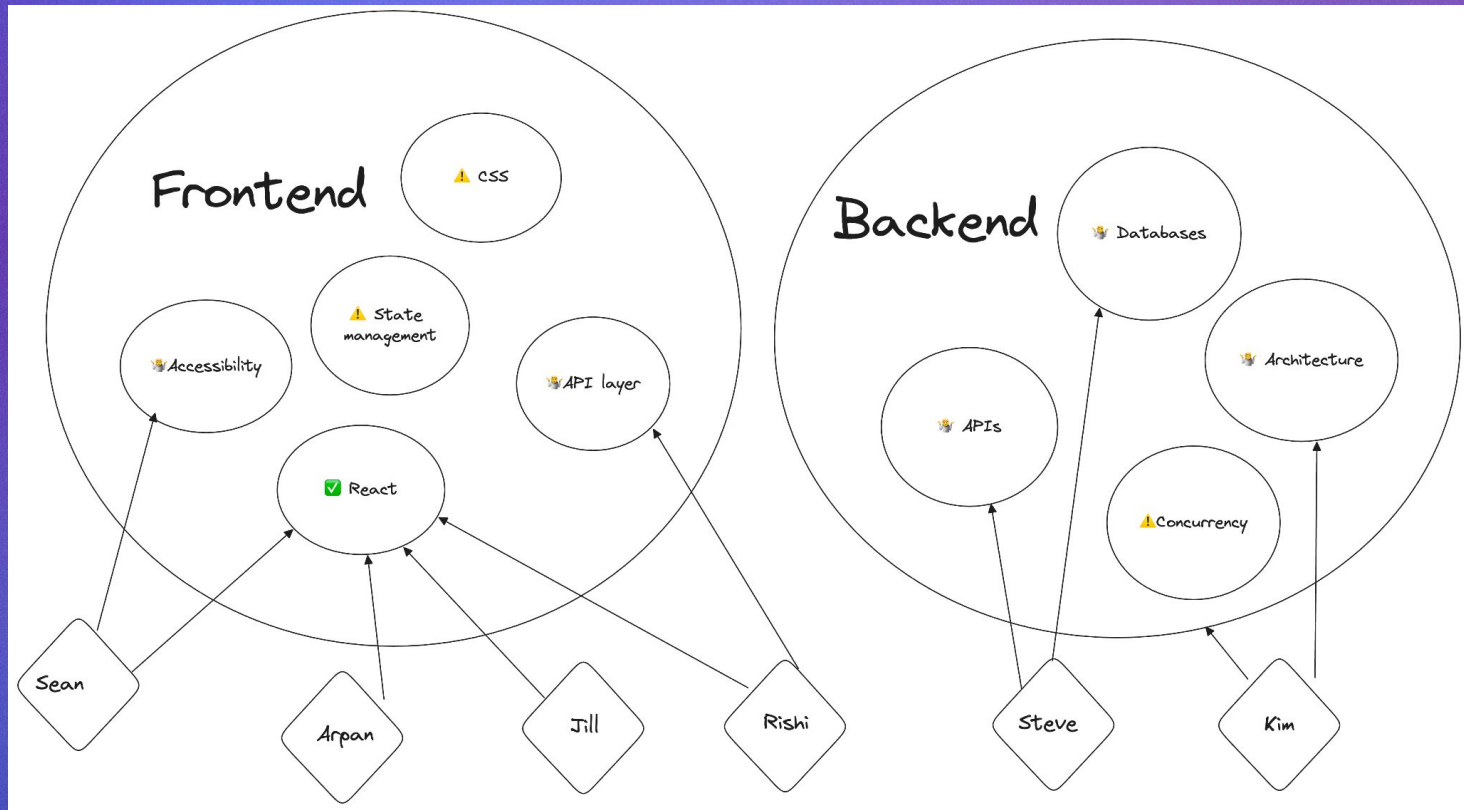
Domain areas



Technical expertise

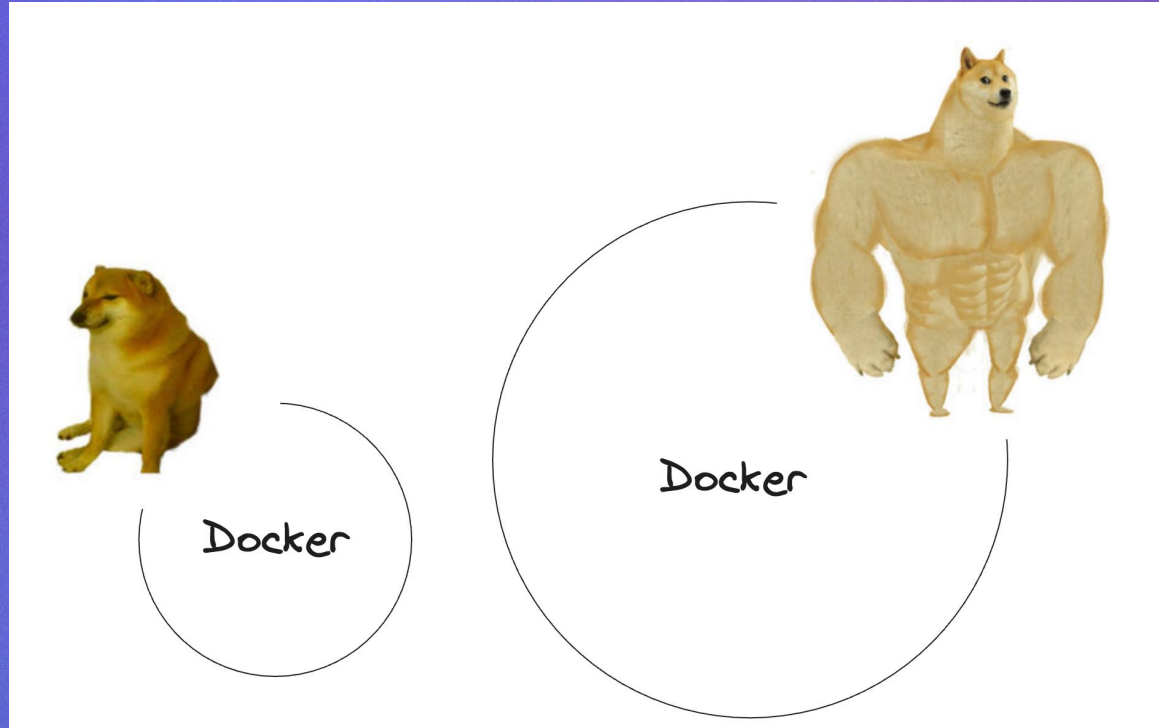


More arrows = More influence

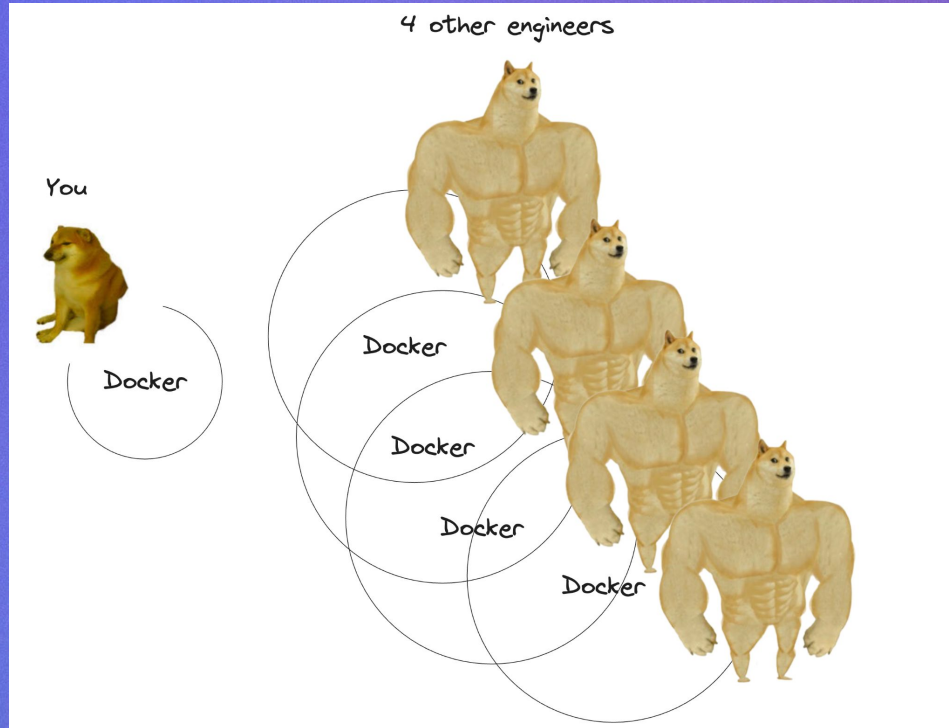


Why it matters • *What a go-to person is* • How to become a go-to person

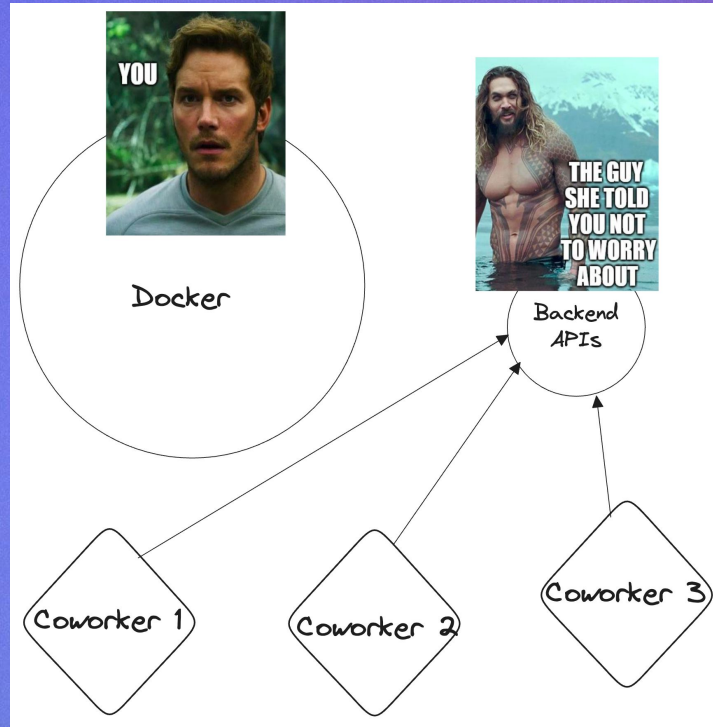
How do your circles compare to others?



⚠ Word of caution - Too many experts



Some of your “circles” matter more than others



Other areas to be known for

“Lint rule” person

- Creates lint rules that support best practices



“Docker” person

- Go to them for docker issues



“Documentation” person

- Strong understanding of docs and where they should be put, how to write them, etc.



“Social event” person

- Organized happy hours, board games, brings the vibes



“Team photo” person

- Always getting group pics, building team bonding



“Process” person

- Runs demo days, planning, retros, etc.





At your company, there's even more!

- Could you also be known for something negative?
Is anyone on your team known for that?
- What other areas could you become the “go-to” person for or known for something?

Module 3

How to become a go-to person

Finding your domain area

1. What are you good at?

- What do people come to you for help with already?
- What do you consistently knock out of the park?

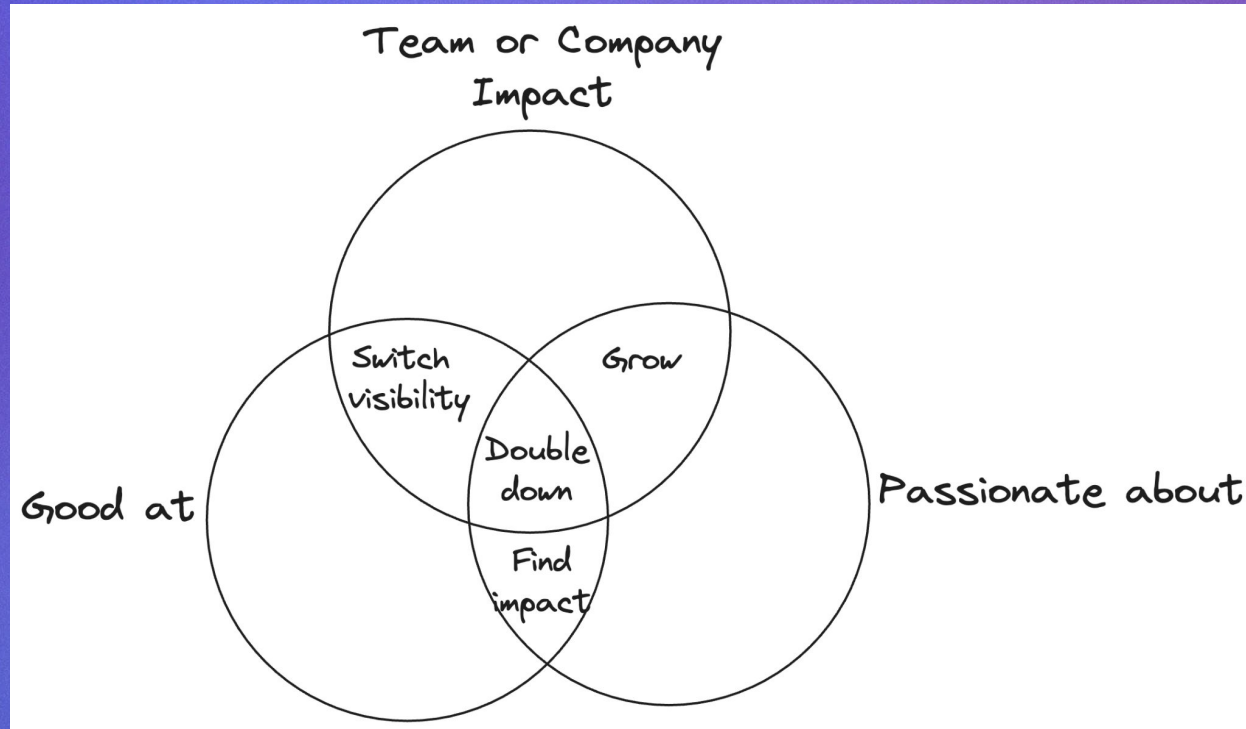
2. What are you passionate about?

- What do you get excitement from doing the most?
- What would you like to be known for in 1-3 years?

3. What has impact?

- What feels painful?
- What does the company value most?

Finding your domain area



Finding your domain area

Team or Company impact	Good at	Passionate about	Action item
✓	✓	✓	Double down. Keep doing what you're doing. You'll be recognized as an expert of an impactful area and this will help you get to Senior. If you'd like, you can start looking for other
✗	✓	✓	Find impact. Try to find why it's not impactful. Is there anything you can do in this area that would be impactful? If not, you may need to find something else to be an expert in.
✓	✗	✓	Grow. Invest in courses, mentorship, books, etc. on the topic to grow in it more. Then start getting visibility in that area.
✓	✓	✗	Switch visibility. Start getting visibility in another area you are passionate about that brings the company impact. Either that or accept your expertise area and the benefits it will bring you.

Take a few minutes to... ✍️

- Write 1-3 things you're good at
- Write 1-3 things you're passionate about
- Do they overlap? Do they have company impact?

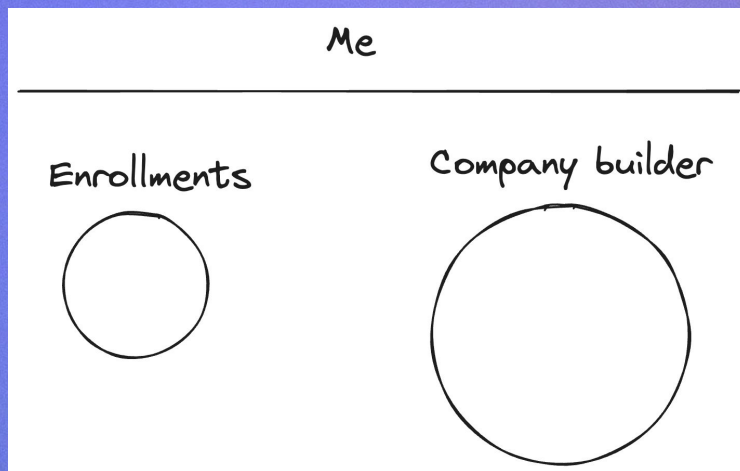
Good at	Passionate about
- Performance ★ - Mentorship - Accessibility - Leadership / process ★	- Performance ★ - Mentorship - Accessibility - Leadership / process ★ - AI 🤖

Exactly what to do - Be visible

1. Lead projects reliably and successfully. Even just by yourself.
2. Be visible in Slack. Answer questions. Make announcements.
3. Run presentations talking about new ways of doing things.
4. Do what you say you'll do. Be reliable.
5. Solve problems in a domain or technological area.

Lead projects reliably and successfully

- One of my first projects: Enrollments revamp
- Later on: Cashout company builder
 - TL;DR: Add circles (domain areas) and increase size of your circles (expertise)



Answer questions

- Be on the lookout for questions in Slack on what you want to start becoming known for.



Jordan Cutler 3:47 PM

Can anyone help me with this GraphQL bug I'm experiencing?

[Link to the error logs](#)

1 reply



Jordan Cutler < 1 minute ago

Yep, I got you!

I think what's happening is: ...

The fix would be to: ...



**Why are presentations one of the best
ways to get visibility?**

Why presentations are great

- They're usually part of some other process (tech talk day, demo day, etc.). Not forced
- Show you as an expert in a particular area
- Biggest form of visibility since its usually full attendance.



**Think back to presentations you gave.
Did you notice a difference after?**

Some personal examples

- CSS Best Practices
- React Testing Library vs Enzyme
- GraphQL Batching
- Accessibility Best Practices
- Demo Company Builder





What else beside presentations?

What are some other things you could do?

- **Writing documentation and sharing about it:**
How to debug performance issues
- **Creating a cool tool that solves a problem for the team:**
Translations CLI
- **Lead an initiative that brings together teams:**
Frontend North Star, API consistency patterns
- **Lead a recurring meeting across teams:** Mobile bi-weekly sync
- **Create a guild or working group:** Frontend guild

Recap

- Why you should become a go-to person
 - More opportunities, faster promotion
- What does a go-to person mean
 - People come to you and think of you for a specific topic area
 - You don't need to know everything, just more than others

Recap - Part 2

- How to become a go-to person
 - Find the intersection: Good at, passionate about, impact
 - Solve problems in those areas
 - Then be visible about it
- Be visible by...
 - Presenting, answering questions, taking on projects, sharing wins, leading initiatives, leading a recurring meeting, participating in guilds, and writing documentation

Action items - Write down...

- **1 Presentation** you can give to your team
- **1-3 Action items** for growing more in that area
 - Read...book
 - Take...course
 - Take on...project
- **Here's a template to help you identify your expertise area**

Thank you 🙏

Where to find more of me

- Newsletter: High Growth Engineer
- Becoming a paid subscriber gets you access to 14 other resources just like the template I linked to (20% discount for Taro members)
- LinkedIn: “Jordan Cutler”
- All my collaborations and appearances elsewhere are documented here